

## TP Link blocks open source router firmware in US

TP Link, a networking hardware vendor, has said that it is going to stop the loading of open source firmware on routers that are sold in the United States. This is in compliance with the new Federal Communications Commission (FCC) requirements.

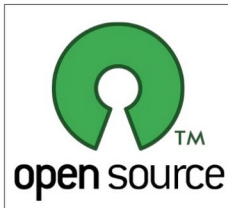
The FCC is trying to restrict interference with other devices by limiting user modifications, which can result in radios operating out of their licensed radio frequency (RF) parameters. The FCC stated that it is not aiming at banning the use of third-party firmware like DD-WRT and OpenWRT. Theoretically, router manufacturers can still load open source firmware, so long as they deploy controls which prevent devices from operating outside their permitted frequency range, types of modulation, power levels, etc.

However, users of open source firmware are worried that hardware manufacturers are going to ban third-party firmware entirely, as it would be the simplest way to comply with the FCC requirements.



As per the FAQ stated in TP-Link's website, the above theory is confirmed. The FAQ accepts that TP-Link is limiting the functionality of its routers. The company stated that, "The FCC requires all manufacturers to prevent user(s) from having any direct ability to change RF parameters (frequency limits, output power, country codes, etc)."

TP-Link further stated that the change is going to be in effect for routers produced on and after June 2, 2016, though the requirements will be incorporated in a gradual manner.



was not the case; rather, the opposite was true. Since the source code is available freely, more people work on such software and take care of its vulnerabilities. De also said that it's tougher to hack into open source software than proprietary software. Among the first government organisations that adopted open source were the US military forces. This was done since it was felt that open source software was a more secure option. Although users of open source can access the algorithm that makes it function, no one can access its encryption key or the set of numbers which act as a password. In the absence of the password, no one can hack into them.

One of the main reasons for the government's push towards open source is the need to incorporate vernacular languages in governance. Also, the government is relying on BOSS (Bharat Operating System Solutions), which is a Linux based operating system to meet this particular need and also to impart improved knowhow on open source across India. However, experts are also of the opinion that the government should focus more on applications and then move on to operating systems.

Further, the IT ministry has given its approval for a policy on 'Collaborative Application Development by Opening the Source Code of Government Applications'. This policy is aimed at increasing the speed of application development and their quick roll-out through the adoption of open source principles. The government is aiming to encourage the reuse of already developed applications. It also intends to boost innovation, both within the government as well as outside, by boosting collaborative development to bring out better products, faster, sources claimed.

## White House to share custom code with open source community

The White House has released the draft of its Source Code Policy that sets out rules regarding sharing of customised software among federal agencies. The policy aims at improving government access to applications as well as lowering development costs. The policy also states that the Obama administration will be launching a pilot programme, which will require federal agencies to release nearly 20 per cent of the third-party-developed custom coding as open source software, making it completely accessible to external developers in the open source community.

As stated by the US CIO, Tony Scott, in a blog post, "Through this policy and pilot programme, we can save taxpayer dollars by avoiding duplicative customer software purchases, and promote innovation and collaboration across federal

to open software would assist the government in cutting costs. However, open source adoption is going to take a lot of time as it needs a certain ecosystem to work smoothly. He said that the government's policy towards it is a positive move.

De further stressed that since open source software is available to the public, there are many who feel that this makes it easy for malicious users to hack into it.

But he went on to clarify that this